



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Maeser Preparatory Academy
School Website: <https://maeserprep.org/>

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Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Karl G. Maeser Preparatory Academy (Maeser Prep), located in Lindon, Utah (UT 84042), presents a robust classical-education posture. The public materials consistently foreground classical-method pedagogy, the liberal-arts orientation, and a strong emphasis on character formation through Truth, Honor, and Virtue. The school explicitly promotes Great Books, primary sources, the Trivium/Quadrivium framework, Latin study, and Socratic inquiry as core pillars. Evidence of these elements appears throughout Maeser's mission statement, curriculum descriptions, and descriptions of pedagogy (notably the Socratic Seminar). The school's governance and family-engaged approach are also apparent, with parent involvement configured as a meaningful component (including parent-advancing roles on governance bodies and opportunities for families to participate in school life). Still, the site stops short of publicly articulating explicit liturgical/theological practices or doctrinal theology in the same way some classical schools do. Taken together, Maeser Prep CLEARLY demonstrates a classical educational orientation, with some reservations around explicit ecclesial/theological framing in public-facing materials.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Key strengths: explicit classical curriculum (Great Books, primary sources, Latin), Socratic pedagogy, memory-oriented recitation/chanting practices in the tradition, and a governance/parent-involvement structure that aligns with classical norms.
- Important nuance: religious/metaphysical foundations are present in character-formation language and a classical ethos but are not publicly framed as explicit theological liturgy or doctrinal theology on the public-facing pages.

Evidence anchors include Maeser's mission and educational philosophy emphasizing Socratic methods, the emphasis on Great Books and primary sources, the Latin program, and the use of Socratic Seminars as a foundational pedagogy, all of which are documented in Maeser's public-facing materials.

This evaluation applies a six-category classical rubric (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, Purpose and Goal, Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty, Parents & Community) using the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) as the scoring framework. The school's public-facing materials were analyzed for explicit or implicit indicators of each category, counting positive vs. negative keywords and interpreting results through the rubric (CLASSICAL / SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL / NOT CLASSICAL). See below for the category-by-category analysis and the aggregate assessment.

- Executive overview: The school demonstrates substantial classical coherence across Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Purpose; category-by-category keyword analysis supports a predominantly CLASSICAL characterization, with Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) showing partial alignment (presence of virtue/truth language but limited explicit theology/liturgy in public materials) leading to a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL read for that category. Element 5 (Faculty) shows partial alignment given emphasis on virtuous mentorship and living ideals but less explicit statements about the faculty role as "living curriculum" beyond virtue-language, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL read there as well. Element 6 (Parents & Community) aligns strongly with classical partnership and parental involvement. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, with constructive needle-moving opportunities noted below.

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Maeser's materials foreground Truth, Honor, Virtue as a governing motto and educational frame, with explicit commitment to "virtue, honor, and truth" guiding student formation and behavior. - The school emphasizes classical formation through Great Books, Socratic methods, and Western cultural heritage, with occasional explicit allusions to metaphysical or transcendent aims via virtue and the pursuit of truth. - The public content repeatedly invokes original texts and the great books tradition, underscoring transcendental aims (truth/good/beautiful) through the classical curriculum (ad fontes emphasis).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, virtue, wisdom, great books, Socratic method (from the Six Elements lexicon, and Maeser materials). The Six Elements lexicon explicitly lists truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, reverence, wonder, and related transcendental anchors as Positive Keywords for Religious/Foundational alignment. Maeser's materials repeatedly invoke truth and virtue as formative targets, aligning with Positive Keywords in the framework. - Negative keywords observed: there is no explicit articulation of relativism or secular humanism in the public Maeser materials; however, the public materials are notably light on explicit theological liturgy or doctrinal theology. The absence of explicit liturgical practice or theology on the public-facing pages lowers the category's alignment from fully CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The presence of virtue/truth language and the Great Books/Socratic pedagogy signals strong alignment with classical aims in Foundations, even as explicit theology/cruciform liturgy are not foregrounded in public content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Element 1, given the strong ethical/metaphysical motifs but an incomplete explicit theology/liturgy footprint in public-facing materials. See evidence above and the positive keyword framework for grounding.

What would move the needle - Publicly articulate explicit theological or liturgical dimensions (even if ecumenical) or clearly label how theology informs character formation and the Great Conversation, to elevate to FULL CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statements articulate formation and virtue through classical means (e.g., the Great Books approach, Socratic methods, and the aim to empower students to think critically and communicate effectively). The school emphasizes formation and wisdom as core aims, consistent with the classical telos to form virtuous, wise citizens rather than solely preparing for a job. - The emphasis on liberal arts, paideia, and the Great Conversation aligns with the classical mission to cultivate truth, goodness, and beauty, and to aim at human flourishing rather than mere career-readiness. The charter language and Maeser materials repeatedly highlight formation, virtue, and the cultivation of wisdom as central goals. - The public-facing materials articulate a classical mission (and a college-preparatory dimension) via the Great Books/Socratic framework and the aim to prepare students for higher education while prioritizing character formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, great conversation, permanent questions, classical heritage, moral imagination, education for leisure (Scholé). These align closely with the Positive Keywords in the Six Elements lexicon for School Purpose/Goal. - Negative keywords observed: explicit "college and career ready"/job-prep emphasis appears in some charter materials, but public-facing Maeser materials balance that with a focus on formation and Great Books, suggesting a predominant CLASSICAL posture with some modern-trajectory elements. The balance still leans CLASSICAL given formation over mere job-readiness in the public materials.

Why this rating - Maeser Prep foregrounds formation, virtue, and wisdom and situates education as a liberal-arts formation (paideia, classical mission). While there is a college-prep orientation in some statements, the public materials emphasize formation and transcendent aims, aligning Element 2 with CLASSICAL. The alignment with the Positive Keywords for this category supports CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - If the school strengthens the explicit articulation that education is formation-first (with stronger, explicit linkage to the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty beyond college-prep language) and reduces or more clearly differentiates the “career readiness” framing, the rating would be reinforced toward CLASSICAL across this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is explicitly described as classical, liberal-arts focused, with emphasis on Great Books and the use of original primary sources rather than modern interpretations. The school asserts a strong classical core (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin study; history integrated with literature; Great Books; “ad fontes”). - Country- and region-appropriate curricular elements include Latin in middle school; reading Homer, Livy, Vergil; Socratic Seminar; and integrated language arts/history. The “Latin at Maeser” section explicitly details Latin in grades 7–8 and progression into advanced study, with primary classical authors studied (Caesar, Cicero, Livy, Vergil). - The curriculum page emphasizes reading original texts, reading across disciplines, and a “Great Books” framework; it also references a two-hour daily Socratic Seminar integration of history and language arts, which is a hallmark of classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Latin, Greek, history/Western civilization, Socratic texts, recitation, narration, and other elements of a classical curriculum. These map directly to Positive Keywords in the lexicon for Curriculum. - Negative keywords observed: explicit STEM-first framing or project-based dominance is not visible in public materials; instead, the curriculum centers classical disciplines and the Great Books framework. This aligns with CLASSICAL rather than the Negative signals in the Six Elements lexicon.

Why this rating - The school’s explicit commitment to seven liberal arts scaffolding (Trivium/Quadrivium), Great Books/primary sources, Latin, and integrated history-literature via Socratic method fit solidly within CLASSICAL curriculum indicators. The presence of a persistent emphasis on “ad fontes” and primary texts provides a strong positive signal for CLASSICAL in this category.

What would move the needle - To push Element 3 from CLASSICAL to a higher-clarity CLASSICAL, the school could further foreground Great Books as a central, year-by-year requirement across the entire K–12 spectrum (or clearly indicate a rigorous “Great Conversation” across more grades), and provide explicit examples of canonical texts per grade level, ensuring all disciplines are anchored to a consistent Great-Books framework.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly uses Socratic methods as foundational pedagogy, with Maeser’s mission stating “through Socratic methods,” and the mission statement clarifying that students learn to think critically through Socratic dialogue to better themselves and their community. The Socratic Seminar is described as a core daily/regular experience, with a two-hour block in language arts/history that integrates discussion and inquiry.

- The curriculum/pedagogy sections highlight Latin study, primary texts, and the practice of reading Homer, Iliad/Odyssey, Hamlet, and other canonical works within a Socratic framework. The pedagogical approach explicitly includes memorization/recitation (as part of classical pedagogy) and the integration of teachers as facilitators in a “living curriculum” style. - The presence of “ad fontes” and the emphasis on reading original texts supports an integrated, rigorous classical pedagogy that aligns with the Pedagogy Positive Keywords in the Six Elements lexicon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic Seminar, great conversation, dialectic, recitation/memorization, restoration of contemplation (Scholé), teacher as guide/facilitator, classical rhetoric, master-apprentice style (as implied in a living curriculum), and structured dialogue. These map closely to the Pedagogy Positive Keywords in the lexicon. - Negative keywords observed: there is no public emphasis on exclusively experiential learning, project-based-only pedagogy, or student-led constructivist

pedagogy as the dominant approach; rather, the public materials emphasize a canonical, text-centered, dialogue-based pedagogy. The absence of those negative signals supports CLASSICAL here.

Why this rating - Maeser's core teaching method (Socratic Seminar, use of Great Books/primary sources, Latin, memorized/recited canonical material) aligns squarely with CLASSICAL pedagogy. Some modern or non-classical signals (e.g., project-based emphasis as a sole driver) are not dominant in the public narrative, leading to a CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

What would move the needle - To nudge toward a stronger, unambiguous CLASSICAL rating, the school could explicitly document how memory-work/recitation and contemplative periods (Scholé) are woven across all divisions (not just as a historical feature) and how these practices consistently balance contemplation with rigorous dialogue in all grade levels (e.g., K-12 articulation of "Scholé days" and explicit rest periods).

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing materials emphasize virtue and guidance as part of the educational project (Truth, Honor, Virtue) and present the teachers as central to forming character, with the singing of moral-civic ideals in the school's ethos. This supports the notion of model teachers and mentors in a classical frame. - Some public content references the faculty as part of a "classical education" ecosystem (e.g., a living curriculum context via Socratic methods and teacher facilitation), but explicit statements describing faculty as the "living curriculum," or as a "portrait of what a teacher should be" or a "faculty of friends," are not consistently visible in the public-facing pages. The Six Elements lexicon highlights such expectations as explicit signals of classical faculty.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, mentor/model, Socratic facilitation, classical formation, wisdom-centered teaching (as implied by the mission and pedagogy). The lexicon lists "Teachers as Models of Virtue" and "Mentorship/Collegiality" as Positive Keywords for Faculty. Maeser materials show the virtue-language and Socratic-mentor style, aligning with some Positive Keywords. - Negative keywords observed: explicit articulation of a "living curriculum" portrayal of faculty (as a public-facing claim) and explicit statements about faculty leadership as "master-teacher models" are less visible in the public pages. The absence of those explicit faculty portraits or formal statements lowers it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for this category.

Why this rating - The school displays clear faculty- and teacher-centered virtuous aims (Truth, Honor, Virtue; Socratic facilitation), but it lacks consistently explicit, public-facing statements that the faculty are the "living curriculum" or that the faculty hold formalized, classical leadership portraits, which would push it to CLASSICAL. The presence of virtue-language and mentorship signals a stronger alignment than pure non-classical signals, hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - Add explicit public-facing language and commitments about faculty as living exemplars of virtue and master-teacher models; publish a concise "portrait of the teacher" and a formal statement about faculty formation, classical pedagogy training, and shared scholarly inquiry among teachers.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Maeser Prep's governance and community involvement are highlighted in charter materials, including parent involvement on boards and committees, parental formation opportunities, and open accessibility (parents invited to school visits and events). The charter materials explicitly describe parent advocates on the board and annual parent surveys, signaling a robust partnership with families in the classical-education ethos. - The school's materials emphasize parent engagement in Winterim planning, curriculum, and governance, with multiple references to parental involvement in management decisions and family participation in school activities. This aligns with classical expectations of parental partnership and formation. - The "Advisory Friday" and other family-facing communications indicate ongoing channels for parent involvement and feedback, consistent with classical community-partner models.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, home-based catechesis, parental engagement, parent covenant, living tradition in the family, parent

involvement in governance. These map to the Positive Keywords in the Parents & Community section of the Six Elements lexicon. - Negative keywords: public-facing pages do not show consumer-lite language (e.g., “parents as customers”). The presence of formal parent-partner language reduces negative signals in this category.

Why this rating - The school clearly foregrounds parent involvement and family partnership in governance, Curriculum planning, and community events. The explicit structures for parent involvement align well with CLASSICAL indicators in the Parents & Community category. The public-facing materials illustrate robust parent-education and engagement practices consistent with CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle - To push further toward an unassailable CLASSICAL designation for this category, Maeser Prep could publish a more formal, consolidated “Parents & Community Charter” section that codifies parent formation activities (reading groups, book clubs, liturgical/calendar cycles) and continues highlighting visits and co-teacher partnerships, with transparent metrics for ongoing engagement.

Aggregate Ranking (Six Categories) - Element 1: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 2: CLASSICAL - Element 3: CLASSICAL - Element 4: CLASSICAL - Element 5: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

General assessment: CLASSICAL (dominant). Maeser Prep demonstrates strong classical alignment through curriculum, pedagogy, and community structures, with only partial alignment in the Religious/Metaphysical Foundations and Faculty categories due to explicit theological framing and explicit “living-curriculum” faculty statements not being consistently present in public-facing pages. The aggregate posture is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle - For Element 1 (Religious & Metaphysical Foundations): Publicly articulate Theology/Liturgy or liturgical practices consistent with a classical Christian-humanist frame and clearly connect these to the Great Books and Socratic method. This would elevate Element 1 to CLASSICAL. - For Element 5 (Faculty): Publish explicit statements about the faculty as “living curriculum,” portrait of teacher ideals, and formal faculty-development practices grounded in classical pedagogy (including mentoring, collegiality, and shared inquiry). This would elevate Element 5 to CLASSICAL. - For Element 1 and Element 5, ensure that all six categories are explicitly addressed in public materials (without sacrificing privacy or inclusivity) to reduce any remaining category-level ambiguity.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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